

# MELLISSA MEISELS

7767 HAVEN HALL  
ANN ARBOR, MI 48109

EMAIL: [meisels@umich.edu](mailto:meisels@umich.edu)  
WEBSITE: [www.mellissameisels.com](http://www.mellissameisels.com)

## Appointments & Affiliations

### UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

Assistant Professor, Department of Political Science 2026 –

### YALE UNIVERSITY

Assistant Professor, Department of Political Science 2025 – 2026

Faculty Affiliate, Institution for Social and Policy Studies

Faculty Affiliate, Center for the Study of American Politics

Postdoctoral Associate, Center for the Study of American Politics 2024 – 2025

### UNIVERSITY OF ROCHESTER

Visiting Scholar, Democracy Center 03/2023

## Education

### VANDERBILT UNIVERSITY

Ph.D. Political Science 2019 – 2024

FIELDS: American Politics, Political Methodology

COMMITTEE: Josh Clinton (chair), Larry Bartels, Alan Wiseman, Danielle Thomsen (UCI)

Graduate Affiliate, Center for the Study of Democratic Institutions

M.A. Political Science 2019 – 2022

### UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES

B.A. Political Science, *magna cum laude* 2015 – 2018

ADVISOR: John Zaller

## Peer-Reviewed Publications

Meisels, Mellissa. 2026. "Candidate Positions, Responsiveness, and Returns to Extremism." *Journal of Politics* 88(2): 681-697.

Meisels, Mellissa. 2026. "Everything in Moderation? The Effect of Extremist Nominations on Individual and Corporate PAC Fundraising." *Political Science Research and Methods* 14(2): 353-369.

Meisels, Mellissa. 2025. "Strategic Campaign Attention to Abortion Before and After *Dobbs*." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 122(20): e2503080122.

Meisels, Mellissa, Joshua D. Clinton, and Gregory A. Huber. 2024. "Giving to the Extreme? Experimental Evidence on Donor Response to Candidate and District Characteristics." *British Journal of Political Science* 54(3): 851-873.

## Working Papers & Works in Progress

Campaign Agendas and Issue Group Strategy in Intraparty Elections (*Revise and resubmit, Quarterly Journal of Political Science*)

— 2023 Political Organizations and Parties Best APSA Paper Award

PRESENTATIONS: APSA MIP Pre-Conference 2023, APSA 2023, JAWS Fall 2023, MPSA 2024, UChicago Harris American Center for Effective Government Conference 2024

Estimating Consensus Ideal Points Using Multi-Source Data (*with Melody Huang and Tiffany M. Tang*)

PRESENTATIONS: PolMeth 2025

Competition and Free-Riding in Electoral Campaigns with Outside Spending (*with Brenton Kenkel*)

PRESENTATIONS: MPSA 2022, APSA MIP Pre-Conference 2022, APSA 2022, VFT 2023

Asymmetrically Polarized Threat of Replacement

PRESENTATIONS: MPSA 2026, APSA 2025

Intraparty Candidate Divergence and Primary Participation

PRESENTATIONS: CBS-Princeton Money in Politics Conference 2026, APSA 2026, PolMeth 2026

Congressional Primary Elections

— Invited chapter in *New Directions in Congressional Politics*, 3rd edition

## Other Publications

Mellissa Meisels. 2024. "Political Donors Prefer Extreme Candidates, but the Competitiveness of the Election and their Opponent's Views Matter Too." *LSE United States Politics & Policy Blog*.

## Awards, Grants, & Fellowships

|                                                                               |             |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| Founder's Medal for First Honors, Vanderbilt University                       | 2025        |
| Best APSA 2023 Paper Award, Political Organizations and Parties Section       | 2024        |
| Provost's Pathbreaking Discovery Award, Vanderbilt University Graduate School | 2024        |
| Outstanding Doctoral Student Award, Vanderbilt University Graduate School     | 2024        |
| Harold Stirling Vanderbilt Award, Vanderbilt University Graduate School       | 2022 – 2024 |
| Russell G. Hamilton Scholar, Vanderbilt University Graduate School            | 2019 – 2024 |
| Outstanding Graduate Research Paper Award, Vanderbilt Political Science       | 2023        |
| Virginia Gray Graduate Student Research Award, APSA POP Section               | 2023        |
| Conference Travel Grant, American Political Science Association               | 2023        |
| J. Leiper Freeman Memorial Award, Vanderbilt Political Science                | 2023        |
| NSF Travel and Participation Award, Society for Political Methodology         | 2023        |
| Travel Grant, Vanderbilt University Graduate School                           | 2023        |
| University Graduate Fellowship, Vanderbilt University Graduate School         | 2019 – 2022 |
| Research Assistant Funding, Vanderbilt ROCCA Lab                              | 2022        |
| NSF Travel and Participation Award, Society for Political Methodology         | 2022        |
| Travel Grant, Vanderbilt University Graduate School                           | 2022        |
| J. Leiper Freeman Memorial Award, Vanderbilt Political Science                | 2021        |
| Lew and Edie Wasserman Grant, UCLA Alumni Association                         | 2016 – 2019 |
| UCLA Alumni Scholarship, UCLA Alumni Association                              | 2015 – 2019 |

## Presentations

### INVITED TALKS

|                                                                                               |         |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|
| Department of Political Science, University of Michigan                                       | 03/2026 |
| Research on Behavior and Institutions Conference, Vanderbilt University ( <i>discussant</i> ) | 03/2026 |
| Data Workshop, Department of Statistical Sciences, University of Toronto                      | 11/2025 |
| Weil, Gotshal & Manges Roundtable, Yale Law School ( <i>discussant</i> )                      | 11/2025 |
| Center for the Study of American Politics Conference, Yale University ( <i>discussant</i> )   | 06/2025 |
| Center for the Study of Democratic Politics, Princeton University                             | 03/2025 |
| Center for Effective Government, UChicago Harris                                              | 06/2024 |
| Department of Government, University of Texas at Austin                                       | 11/2023 |
| Department of Political Science, Syracuse University                                          | 11/2023 |
| Department of Political Science, University of California, San Diego                          | 11/2023 |
| Department of Political Science, Yale University                                              | 11/2023 |
| Department of Political Science, Stanford University                                          | 11/2023 |
| Department of Government, American University                                                 | 10/2023 |
| Department of Political Science, University of Rochester                                      | 03/2023 |

## OTHER SMALL CONFERENCES & WORKSHOPS

|                                                                          |             |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| CBS–Princeton Conference on Money in Politics                            | 2026        |
| Yale Political Science Junior Faculty Working Group                      | 2025        |
| Junior Americanist Workshop Series (JAWS)                                | 2023        |
| Virtual Formal Theory Workshop                                           | 2023        |
| Vanderbilt Political Science IDEAS Symposium                             | 2023        |
| Vanderbilt American Politics Workshop                                    | 2022 – 2023 |
| Money in Politics Pre-Conference, American Political Science Association | 2021 – 2023 |

## ANNUAL MEETINGS

|                                        |                  |
|----------------------------------------|------------------|
| Society for Political Methodology      | 2022, 2023, 2025 |
| American Political Science Association | 2021 – 2026      |
| Midwest Political Science Association  | 2021 – 2026      |

## Teaching

### INSTRUCTOR OF RECORD, YALE UNIVERSITY

|                                                                  |      |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| PLSC 3256/8050 — Elite Behavior in Congressional Elections (U/G) | 2026 |
| PLSC 2255 — Special Interest Politics in the US (U)              | 2025 |

### TEACHING ASSISTANT, VANDERBILT UNIVERSITY

|                                                       |      |
|-------------------------------------------------------|------|
| PSCI 3893 — American Democracy and Dissent            | 2024 |
| PSCI 3244 — The Legislative Process                   | 2023 |
| PSCI 3260 — Introduction to American Law              | 2022 |
| PSCI 2260 — Constitutional Law                        | 2022 |
| DSCI 1000 — Data Science: How Data Shape Our World    | 2021 |
| PSCI 2300 — Introduction to Data Science for Politics | 2021 |
| PSCI 1150 — U.S. Elections                            | 2020 |

## Service

|                                                                            |             |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| Committee Member, Eldersveld Emerging Scholars Conference                  | 2026        |
| Council Member, APSA Political Organizations and Parties Section           | 2026 – 2028 |
| Excellence in Mentoring Award Committee, Society for Political Methodology | 2026        |
| Graduate Admissions Committee, Yale Department of Political Science        | 2025 – 2026 |
| Coordinator, Yale American Politics and Policy Workshop                    | 2025 – 2026 |
| Poster Award Committee, Society for Political Methodology                  | 2025        |
| Co-President, Vanderbilt Political Science Graduate Student Association    | 2021 – 2023 |

Panel Chair, Women in Legislative Studies Conference

2022

Referee for *Party Politics*, *Electoral Studies*, *Journal of Politics*, *American Journal of Political Science*, *Legislative Studies Quarterly*, *Political Behavior*, *American Political Science Review*, *Journal of Information Technology and Politics*, *Brookings Institution Press*